

Think College Wyoming: A Rural State Perspective

A Review by Anya Tracy

DESCRIPTION OF PROGRAM

Wyoming is a primarily rural state, which presents unique challenges to individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD). For example, many families travel to neighboring states for complex medical needs; in addition, rural individuals with IDD have more limited access to specific professionals, services, expertise, and technologies than people living in urban and suburban areas. While it is the 9th largest state, Wyoming has a population of only about 560,000, making it the least populated state in the country^[1]. Think College Wyoming (TCW) developed out of a perceived lack of supported higher education opportunities for individuals with IDD throughout the state.

With strategic planning support from Think College, the Wyoming Institute for Disabilities (WIND)—the state University Center for Excellence in Developmental Disabilities located at the University of Wyoming—developed community and agency partnerships in towns where community colleges were located. WIND then employed a TCW coordinator to oversee support processes necessary to pilot inclusive postsecondary education opportunities for selected students.

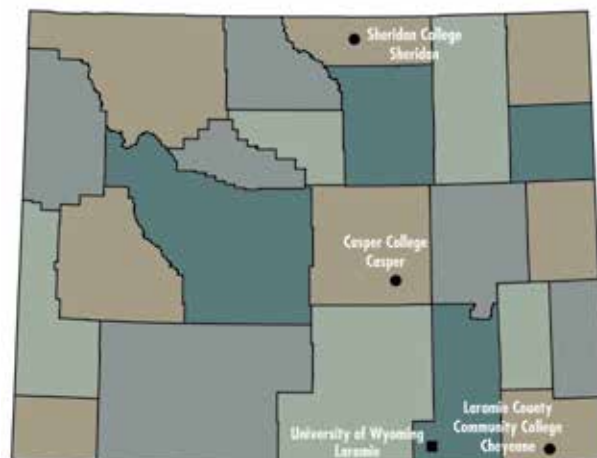
To develop the most appropriate approach for Wyoming, survey and narrative response questions were sent to potential students, family members, educators, and other stakeholders. The program development team also investigated existing Think College models^[2]. Ultimately, they chose the inclusive individual supports model because of the rural nature of Wyoming and family preference for close location to the student. The characteristics of this model include services

Goal

People with intellectual disabilities in Wyoming have the choice to attend college with supports that are individualized.

driven by the individual student's vision and career goals, the student participating academically and socially as any other student would, and the absence of a program base on campus or anywhere else (Grigal & Hart, 2010, p. 49).

Following this model, the selection committee identified three pilot students from three communities in the state: Sheridan, Cheyenne, and Casper. At the time of this review, the student from Sheridan had completed her two years in the program, so this review focuses on the students who have been participating in Cheyenne and Casper. The information was gathered by conducting interviews among the students, their family members, college representatives, and other team members.



Think College Wyoming, University of Wyoming, has served three of seven community colleges across this geographically large state.

Each student was selected based on the following criteria^[3]:

- Has an intellectual disability and is between the ages of 21 and 26
- Completed high school with a certificate of completion, a modified standard, or special diploma
- Has expressed a strong interest in attending college
- Is willing to commit to a two-year college experience and take up to two classes per semester

The students chose to develop knowledge and skills in the following areas over the course of the program: academic achievement, career development, self-determination, campus/community engagement, and independent living. Each student’s progress has been monitored by the program coordinator and members of the planning team.

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**THINK COLLEGE WYOMING ON TWO
CAMPUSES**
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Casper

Brittany (see student profile) has been a student at Casper College. She enjoys spending time with her animals, bowling on a weekly league team, participating in the Special Olympics bowling team, watching professional wrestling, Japanese animation (animé), and creative writing. She lives with her parents in Casper.

Because employment is one of the pillars of Think College Wyoming (TCW), Brittany was required to get a job during the program. She eventually found work at a local pizza restaurant, and reports enjoying her job and the financial choices she has made as a result of being employed.

In her first year of TCW, she took two history classes (one each semester), and plans to

Brittany

Brittany attends Casper College through Think College Wyoming. When asked how she would describe herself, Brittany said, “I’m easy going. I’m understanding. I like bowling. I’ve been watching wrestling for thirteen years. I love animé; I read four different series. I’m writing a book about me and wrestling. My dogs are a hobby. With work and school I am hardworking.” She lives with her parents in Casper and works at a local pizza restaurant. When asked about the hardest moment she experienced during the Think College process, she kept a positive outlook. “I’ve liked everything. Maybe finding my way around was the hardest. I had first day jitters when I started working.” Brittany reports greater self-confidence and financial autonomy due to her experience in college. “I make my own money. I was able to buy my own computer. Going to class made me more self-confident.” Brittany hopes that Think College Wyoming and going to classes will help her achieve her dream job.



take an American Sign Language class during her third semester. One day, Brittany hopes to work in an assistant role in professional sports.

The TCW coordinator was responsible for organizing all meetings between members of the Casper TCW team and periodically checking on the student and her progress. Members of the student's team included a vocational rehabilitation (VR) employment consultant and a VR counselor, an intern from the Student Success Center, the Student Success Center director, the student's mother, the Casper College disability services counselor, an assistant professor from the Occupational Therapy Department, and the student's former Medicaid waiver case manager. All team members were expected to attend periodic meetings.

The Casper TCW program developed a partnership with the University of North Dakota occupational therapy (OT) master's program on campus. Students from the OT program provided peer mentorship for Brittany, a partnership from which all involved claimed benefits. The Student Success Center was also able to designate a social work intern to act as the TCW student's "case manager." This was also considered a beneficial partnership.

Cheyenne

Kevin (see student profile), the student selected from Cheyenne, attends Laramie County Community College. During his time in TCW, Kevin found employment at a local Goodwill. He enjoys Magic the Gathering (card game and videos), comic books, Special Olympics, and coaching basketball. He lives with one roommate in a supported living apartment. He has a guardian who was minimally involved in his TCW experience. In his first year of TCW, he took an Introduction to Writing class and the College Success class. One day, Kevin hopes to become a

Kevin

Kevin attends Laramie County Community College in Cheyenne, Wyoming. Kevin describes himself as "someone who is big on sports and action movies." When asked why he decided to go to college and participate in Think College Wyoming, he said, "I was questioning it because I wasn't so sure because I didn't have a lot of the knowledge I needed for it and because of my disability. I was nervous. I knew I wanted to do something with my life. Do something I like in life because not every job is for every person." Kevin works at a local Goodwill facility and has become knowledgeable at his job and even trains new employees. He reports, "I clean bins for the stuff, take care of the books, mark them. I know how to do basically everything." When asked how he thought his experience in Think College would help him in the future he said, "I think it will help me with mainly school. But I think it'll help me if I'm having trouble with something - it'll help me get the things I need to succeed."



physical education teacher.

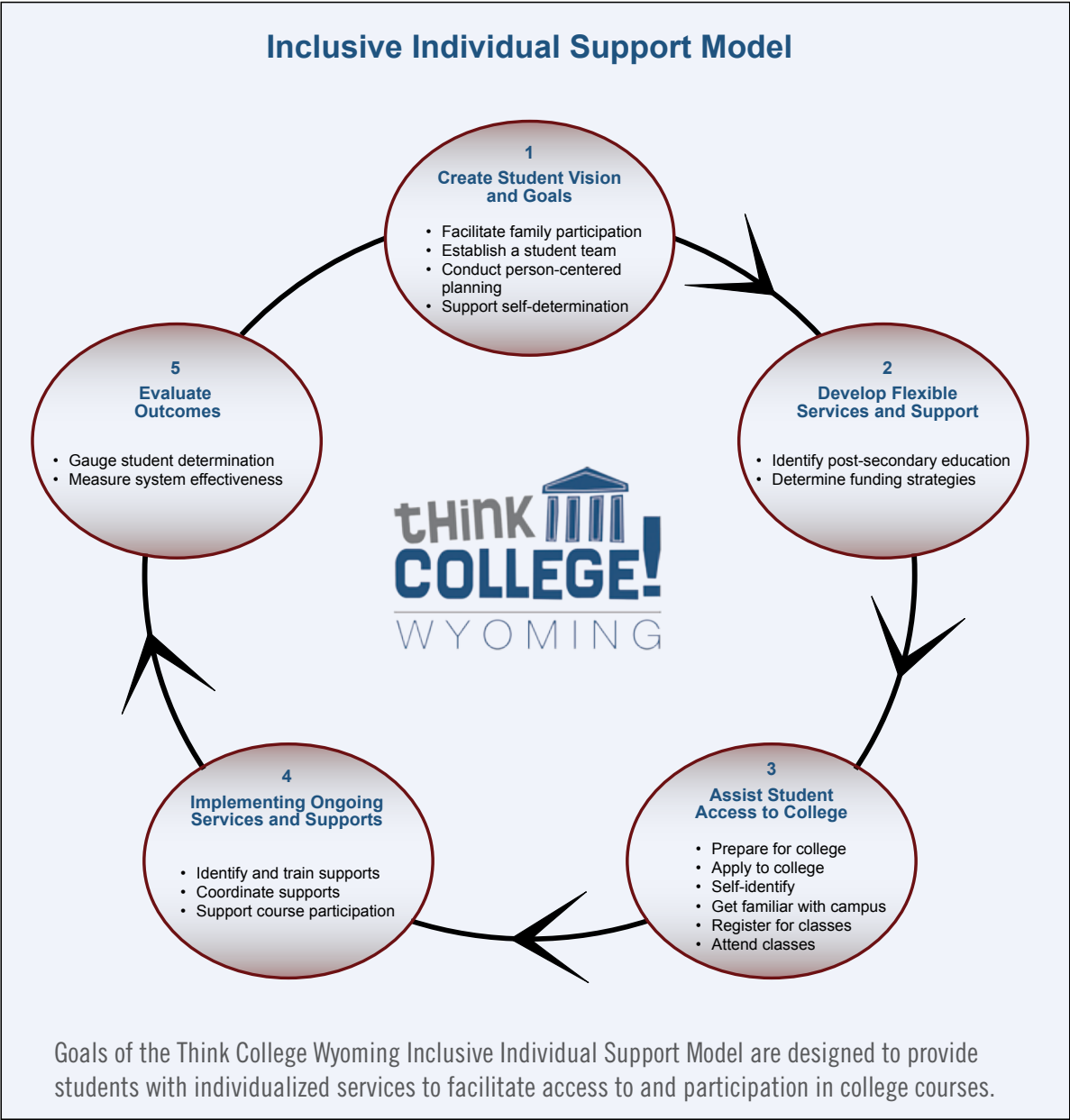
The same TCW coordinator for the Casper program was responsible for coordinating the Cheyenne program and monitoring the student’s progress. Because the coordinator lives in Casper, she attended some meetings via Zoom, a video conferencing platform.

The members of the student’s team included his VR counselor, the Laramie County Community College disability support services coordinator, his case manager, his guardian, and his residential facility coordinator. All team members were expected to attend meetings every other month; however, due to scheduling difficulties

not all team members attended all meetings. The TCW program in Cheyenne has not developed a peer mentoring program, but the student reported asking students in his classes for assistance.

AREAS OF STRENGTH FOR THINK COLLEGE WYOMING

Based on information obtained during the interview process, the reviewer categorized general areas of strength for TCW overall, as well as strengths specific to the individual sites.



Collaboration

Members on both the Laramie County Community College and Casper College teams described their experience in the program as collaborative. The team approach to the college experience was considered to be effective for the student and informative for the team members.

One member said, “I really like how focused it [has been] on the individual and there’s somebody from each of the different points to help the individual with achieving her goal.” Both students said they felt supported by their teams and fully involved in the planning process for their semester goals.

Independence (Social Skills, Confidence)

Both students experienced increased independence, social skills, and confidence as reported by the individuals themselves and members of their teams. When asked how TCW will help him in the future, Kevin reported, “I think it [TCW] will ... help me get the things I need to succeed.” The Casper student observed, “Going to class made me more self-confident.”

When asked what they observed in terms of students’ growth after one year of participation in TCW, all team members in both locations mentioned independence and increased self-confidence. One team member said, “[Brittany grew most in] confidence and independence. The student is much more willing to stand up for herself. Brittany really sees the value in being able to talk for herself and make her own decisions.”

Allowing students in TCW to participate in typical college and work experiences not only increased these students’ sense of independence, but also encouraged team and family members to allow the student to take risks common to young adults and garner the rewards of being independent. One member highlighted this dynamic: “[The student grew in] independence, confidence, pride, empowerment. Even for the student’s mother, being able to let go a little bit and allow her to

experience things without fear—I think they both benefitted.”

Another team member commented, “I like the fact that there’s a push, if you will, not just on the individual but also on the support system to really encourage greater independence levels.”

Growth and Lifelong Learning

It was apparent both students experienced substantial growth in self-confidence, and gained academic, social, and job skills during their first year of TCW. Both students expressed that they enjoyed the program in general and all the things they were learning through the various aspects of their experiences.

Kevin said that he learned many academic skills during TCW, including how to appropriately ask for help when he struggled: “I didn’t learn anything about how to do college work, so I was learning it all from the start. I didn’t exactly go to high school completely. But I got better and better. Every time I saw something I needed help with or to work on, I would go get help.”

When asked why he decided to apply to the program, he said, “I just heard about the program and then I decided to give it a try. I knew I wanted to do something with my life.” TCW allowed Kevin the opportunity to expand his working horizons and gain skills applicable to diverse environments that might not have been available otherwise.

Brittany explained that her original goals focused on gaining skills to “achieve my dream job.” After the program, she stated, “TCW helped me figure out what I want to do.” For her, participating in TCW provided with an expanded vision for her life and motivation to learn in different classes to be better prepared to obtain employment.

Members from both teams commented upon the growth seen in the students. One member said, “I watched the student from the beginning and it seemed like everyone held onto the student very tight and circled around them. By the end,

through the process, you could feel them all loosen up and you could feel the student start to be empowered and confident and willing to take on some challenges.” Both students showed aptitude for life-long learning by working through challenging situations and reflecting on their strengths and weaknesses.

Not only did the students grow, but team members expressed growth and learning in their own professional domains. One member said, “Professionally, I think it’s just opened that door for me to be more familiar and creating a level of comfort with different people with different disabilities.”

Peer and Mentor Support

One of the strengths of the Casper program was the strong relationship its staff developed with the OT program on campus. A TCW team member explained: “We connected well with the OT students and the program that they have. That was an ideal collaboration.” The Casper student said, “Everything has been awesome. I’m really excited for next semester. I want it to get here sooner. The OT students were a lot of fun to work with.”

The Casper student had scheduled weekly meeting times after her class with students from the OT program to go over course material. She also ate with them in the cafeteria and participated in on-campus social activities with them.

Another beneficial mentor relationship on the Casper campus was the Student Success Center intern from the social work department. The student success coordinator reported, “The only reason we could make Think College happen here was because we had a social work intern who essentially became the student’s case manager.” The intern was the point person on campus for the student and her family. She periodically checked in on the student and provided her with academic guidance.

AREAS FOR IMPROVEMENT FOR THINK COLLEGE WYOMING

Peer Mentorship

In contrast to Brittany’s mentoring in the Casper program, Kevin did not have the benefit of a formal peer network, which may have impacted his academic and social experience. While he expressed that his happiest moment was “meeting new friends (in my classes) and hanging out with them sometimes,” the depth and scope of these relationships was unclear. Members of the student’s team expressed concerns about his difficulty with academic work, some of which may have been addressed through peer mentoring in organization, studying, and content. In addition, Kevin tended to isolate himself, and did not participate in any activities on campus outside of classes.

One campus representative observed, “I don’t know that he’s necessarily grown friend-wise or is involved in other activities, but I do know the student is out here quite a bit so that’s probably a positive thing for him.” Clearly, Kevin enjoyed the campus experience, but might have benefited from a more structured peer/mentor support system.

Team Member Issues

Most of the challenges identified by members of both TCW teams can be categorized as team member issues. Specific concerns included scheduling conflicts, inconsistent attendance of key members at team meetings, too many members on the teams, and lack of commitment from team members.

The Cheyenne VR representative said that it was difficult for her department to contribute to meetings, as her schedule was booked months out and meetings were not scheduled far enough in advance: “It’s very hard to tie to VR. It was unfortunate the meetings never worked out.”

A member of the Cheyenne team from Laramie County Community College said, “I don’t always feel like the team is on the same page.”

It was also difficult for the TCW coordinator to be at some meetings in person, because she did not live in Cheyenne. One team member stated that competing perceptions were challenging: “I think the Think College program is different than what the student and most of the team wanted, so that’s been kind of frustrating.”

The Casper team experienced fewer issues with team structure. However, there was still room for improvement. One member reported, “I don’t know if there’s just too many people involved because I feel like the team we are working with is very big.” The size of the group and absence of some team members from meetings resulted in miscommunication. Members of the initial team felt that the addition of the OT students sometimes complicated meeting times because of their variable schedules. One member said, “We need to have the right people on the team, but not too many people on the team.”

Program Structure

Teams at both program sites expressed similar areas of improvement for overall program structure. Suggestions included broadening the age range for eligible students, finding more funding, and connecting with more potential partners.

Team members agreed that students younger than 21 should be eligible for the program. According to one secondary education professional, “I think the part I didn’t like [about TCW] was that it wasn’t something that students who were still in school could begin. I’d really like to have those opportunities for the 18- to 21-year-olds to be involved in the process, like a dual enrollment.” Many Think College Programs around the country provide Think College as a dual enrollment option.

It was also agreed upon that funding for tuition and related expenses needs to be available to the student. As one team member explained, “I think it is absolutely a program worthy of continuing and expanding. One of the first things that has to be adjusted is the funding the person has available.”

Potential partners identified by team members included housing authorities, mental health support systems, life coaches, job coaches, employment counselors, and transportation representatives. One TCW team member suggested that the faculty that taught the TCW students’ classes could be involved in the meeting process. A representative from VR suggested, “It’d be great if we draw in more employers, especially ones connected to things of value like the early childhood programs.”

GOALS FOR THINK COLLEGE WYOMING

Based on the identified areas of strengths and weaknesses for the program, we propose four recommendations for the successful continuation of the program:

- Providing a clear explanation and overall understanding of the purpose and functioning of TCW for all parties involved.
- Ensuring there is a structured peer/mentorship support program available for all TCW students.
- Identifying sources of funding for TCW students to go towards tuition and expenses.
- Researching the potential for dual enrollment for students and, if feasible, lowering the eligibility age to 18.

One TCW student’s high school teacher expressed the importance of having a program like TCW in Wyoming: “I think it’s really sad if we don’t figure out a way to keep it in Wyoming. If this program has time to be in place and evolve and gain some credibility with people it could be a really nice avenue for future students.”

Though the program has areas for improvement, TCW is positively changing individuals’ lives. As it continues to evolve, this initiative will have an even greater impact in the future.

NOTES

[1] State of Wyoming. (2011). Wyoming facts and symbols.
Retrieved from <http://www.wyo.gov/about-wyoming/wyoming-facts-and-symbols>

[2] See Grigal & Hart (2010, pp. 49-50) for more detailed information about the three model frameworks: the mixed/hybrid, the substantially separate, and the inclusive individual supports.

[3] Wyoming Institute for Disabilities: Think College. (n.d.) Who should apply.
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